Barn Owls Make a Surprise Home in Manhattan

From: NPR World Mined: 2026-10-16 3 min read

A family of barn owls has moved into a water tower on top of a building in Manhattan, in New York City. The building is on West 75th Street, close to Central Park.

Andrew Farnsworth, a bird scientist at the Cornell Lab of **Ornithology**, says this is the first time barn owls are known to have **nested** in Manhattan in recorded history.

A neighbor named Elisabeth Williams told a local news outlet about the owls on October 6. A **birder** named David Barrett says he has seen at least one adult owl and five young owls, called **fledglings**.

Barn owls are very rare in New York City parks. Now crowds gather every night hoping to see them. Neighbors had heard loud **screeching** at night since September. That **screech** is how barn owls talk to each other. "I think we're about to become **birders**," Williams said.

Word Treasure

nested -- Made a home where birds lay eggs and raise babies.
ornithology -- The science of studying birds.
fledglings -- Young birds that are learning to fly.
birder -- A person who likes to watch birds.
screech -- A loud, high, sharp sound.

Background you need

Barn owls have pale, heart-shaped faces and hunt small animals at night.

They like quiet, high places to nest, like barns, trees or towers.

Many buildings in New York City have water towers on their roofs.

Break it down

WHO: A family of barn owls and the New Yorkers who watch them
WHAT: Barn owls nested in Manhattan for the first time in recorded history
WHERE: A water tower on West 75th Street, near Central Park
WHY: The owls found a high, quiet spot to raise their young

Why it matters

Even in a big city, wild animals can find homes, and kids can watch and learn about them.

Test what you remember

1. Where did the barn owls make their home?

- (A) In a park bench
- (B) In a water tower
- (C) In a subway
- (D) In a tree

2. Which park is the building close to?

- (A) Hyde Park
- (B) Yellowstone
- (C) Golden Gate Park
- (D) Central Park

3. What are young owls called?

- (A) Kits
- (B) Fledglings
- (C) Cubs
- (D) Puppies

4. When did Elisabeth Williams tell a news outlet about the owls?

- (A) October 6
- (B) September 1
- (C) June 10
- (D) December 25

5. Why do barn owls screech?

- (A) To talk to each other
- (B) Because they are cold
- (C) To scare cars
- (D) To sing songs

6. How many young owls has David Barrett seen?

- (A) Twenty
- (B) One
- (C) None
- (D) At least five

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: D 3: B 4: A 5: A 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Andrew Farnsworth, bird scientist: Says this is the first time barn owls are known to have nested in Manhattan.

2. Elisabeth Williams, neighbor: Says her family may become birders.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):